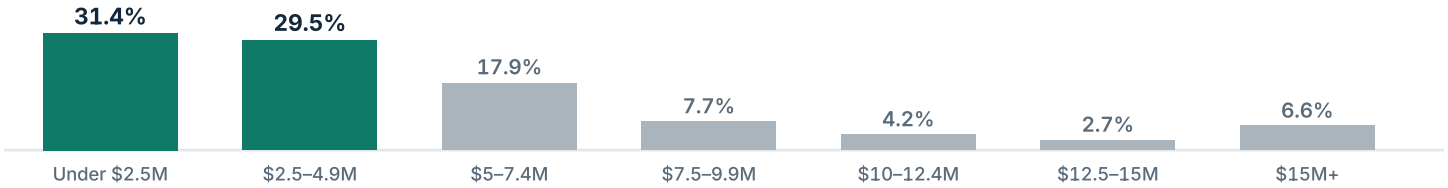
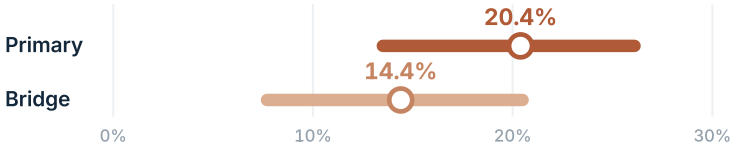
Seed-Stage Benchmarks

Session 01 · Seed & First Institutional Capital
Data: **Carta** · re-visualized for classroom use

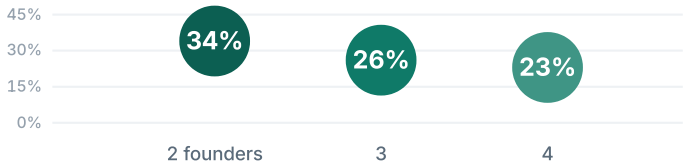
Six in ten seed rounds are under $5M · amount raised, 2025



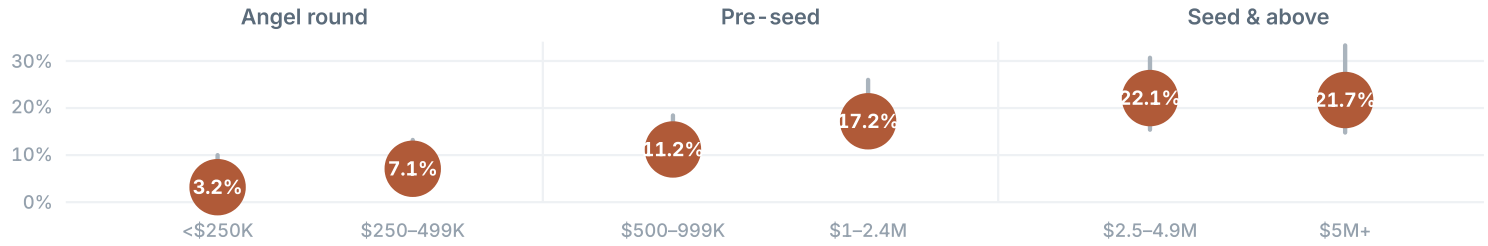
A priced seed sells ~a fifth · % sold to investors



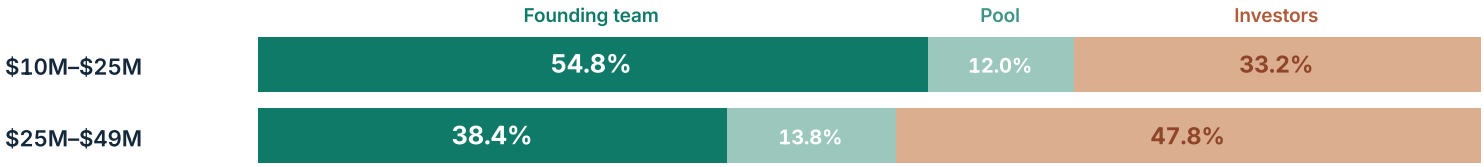
Fewer founders, bigger slice · median per founder



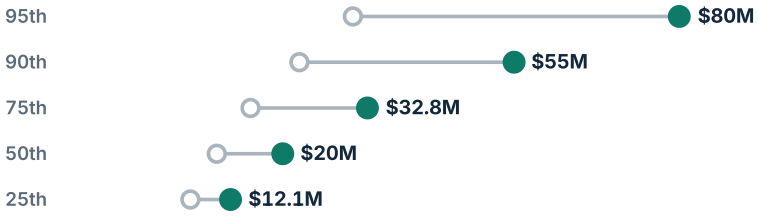
The more you raise on a SAFE, the more you give up · dot = median, line = middle-50%



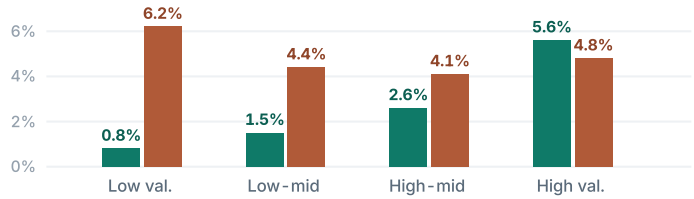
Founders' majority fades as valuations rise · median ownership by post-money valuation



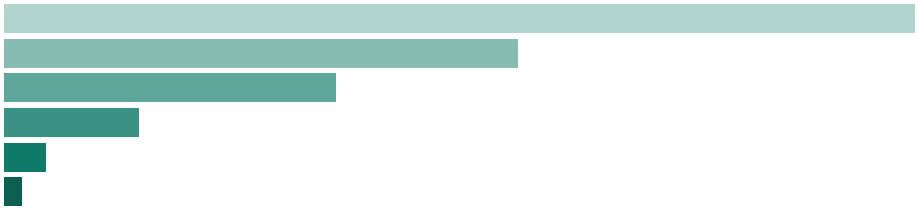
Seed valuations grew fastest at the top · 2018 → 2025



Where to raise · unicorn vs 50× odds by seed val.



Each round, most of the field drops out · class of 2018, as of Jan 2025



4,369 incorporated in 2018 · 100%
2,464 raised a Seed · 56.4%
1,588 raised Series A · 36.4%
643 raised Series B · 14.8%
194 raised Series C · 4.4%
50 raised Series D+ · 1.1%

By Jan 2025: **62% closed** · **32% still live** · 5.5% M&A · 1.3% unicorn · 0.3% IPO

How each role vests its equity · most common terms, U.S. startups

PERSONA / EQUITY TYPE	VESTS OVER	CLIFF?	FREQUENCY
Founders · ISOs	4 years	1 year (or none)	Monthly
Advisors · NSOs	2 years	6 months	Monthly
Independent board · NSOs	4 years	1 year	Quarterly
Employees · ISOs or RSUs	4 years	1 year	Monthly

Every figure re-visualized from Carta's public data, attributed for classroom use.